Keeping a Vigil

BECAUSE the 1984-batch Assam Meghalaya cadre IAS officer has been at the helm of affairs as home secretary since 2019 and received three one-year extensions—proof of the Modi government's trust in his abilities

INSURGENCY SPECIALIST **Bhalla is the government's key man when it comes to taking stock of the security situation in Jammu and Kashmir and talking to rebel groups of the northeastern states**

BECAUSE he is closely monitoring the fragile situation in Punjab in view of the situation arising out of radical preacher Amritpal's case. On his recent visit to the UK, Bhalla specifically conveyed India's concerns over the misuse of the UK's asylum status by pro-Khalistani elements to aid and abet terrorist activities in India

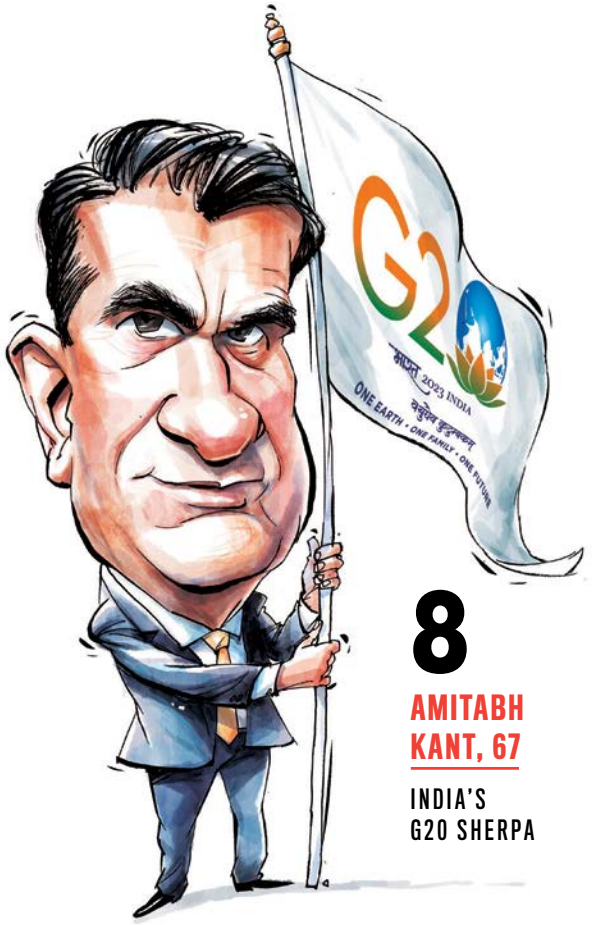
BECAUSE Bhalla as the home secretary oversaw the passage of key and contentious legislations like the CAA, and abrogation of J&K's special status along with the setting up of the Ram Mandir Trust and Covid-19 management



direction of the political winds—Opposition parties claim the fear of an ED probe makes many either join hands with or take membership of the BJP, ruling at the Centre. Mishra is loved and loathed by politicians, depending on which side of the divide they are on

MAN OF MANY INTERESTS **Before joining the IRS, Mishra worked at the Central Drug Research Institute. He runs 10 km daily and practises intermittent fasting. He loves Urdu poetry too**

BECAUSE he has received three extensions after completing his term as ED director, his tenure lasting beyond the three years of his original term when he was appointed in 2018. When his first extension was challenged in the SC, the government brought in an ordinance, and later pushed through a bill in Parliament, to extend his tenure to five years



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AMITABH KANT, 67

INDIA'S G20 SHERPA

GLOBE MEISTER

BECAUSE in July 2022, he was picked as India's G20 Sherpa in its presidency year after serving six years as CEO of Niti Aayog. He is in charge of negotiations and building consensus among the G20 leaders

WAYLAID **Kant was said to be keen on the chairmanship of the Competition Commission of India post-retirement, when PM Modi made him Niti Aayog CEO, saying he wasn't 'cut out' for the CCI job**

BECAUSE he has been the architect of some key reforms in the Modi regime, including Make in India, the Aspirational Districts programme, Start-Up India and the asset monetisation programme

BECAUSE he is now advocating issues like climate change and renewable energy, green hydrogen and frontier technologies such as artificial intelligence, blockchain and drones on various platforms

Illustration by **ROUNAK PATRA**